

Anthropic: Pricing the Pre-IPO AI Leader

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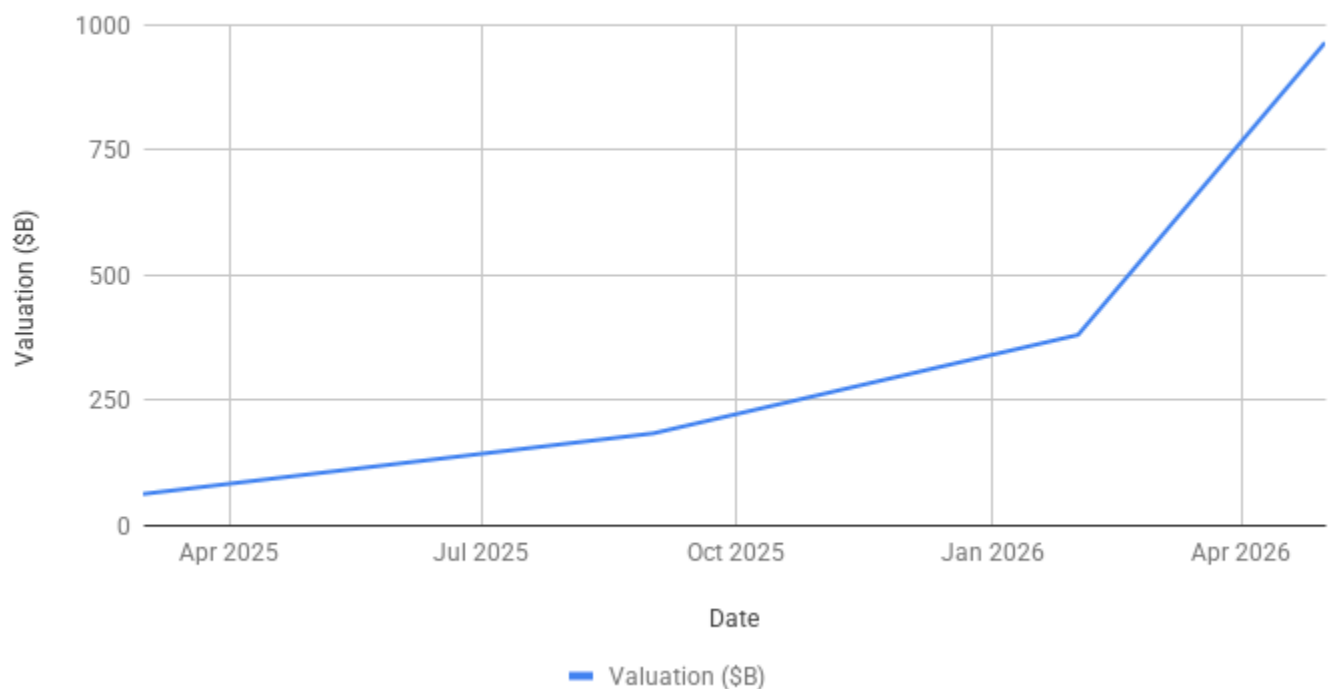
Why I Picked This Company

Anthropic, the AI company that makes Claude, is a strange company to research because you actually can't buy stock in it. It's still private. But in June 2026 it quietly filed confidential paperwork with the SEC for an IPO, which is basically the first real step toward going public (Reddy, 2026). That got me curious about how a company even gets priced before it has a stock ticker, and whether the number attached to it right now makes sense or is running ahead of itself. I also picked Anthropic because I actually use its product. I wanted to see if my own experience as a user lined up with what the financial numbers were telling investors. My argument in this paper is that Anthropic's revenue growth and cost efficiency are real and well supported, but its valuation has grown faster than either one, which means the price investors are paying is currently ahead of what the business has actually proven so far.

The Valuation Timeline

The number itself is hard to wrap your head around. In March 2025, Anthropic was valued at about \$61.5 billion. By September 2025 that had jumped to \$183 billion. In February 2026 it was \$380 billion (Sacra, 2026). Then in May 2026, it raised another \$65 billion and hit a \$965 billion valuation (Anthropic, 2026). That's almost 16 times higher than it was 14 months earlier, and it's the same company, selling the same core product, in the same market the entire time. Nothing about what Anthropic sells changed that dramatically in 14 months. What changed was how much investors were willing to pay for a piece of it.

Anthropic Valuation Over Time



What's Actually Driving This

Some of that jump makes sense because the business itself is growing, not just the hype around it. Anthropic's revenue was reportedly around \$47 billion on a run-rate basis by May 2026 (Anthropic, 2026), up a lot from where it started the year. That growth isn't just a headline to me. I use Claude pretty much every day, for coding help, practice for quizzes and tests, and personal projects. I don't think I'm unusual in that either. Kids at my school use it, and people I know use

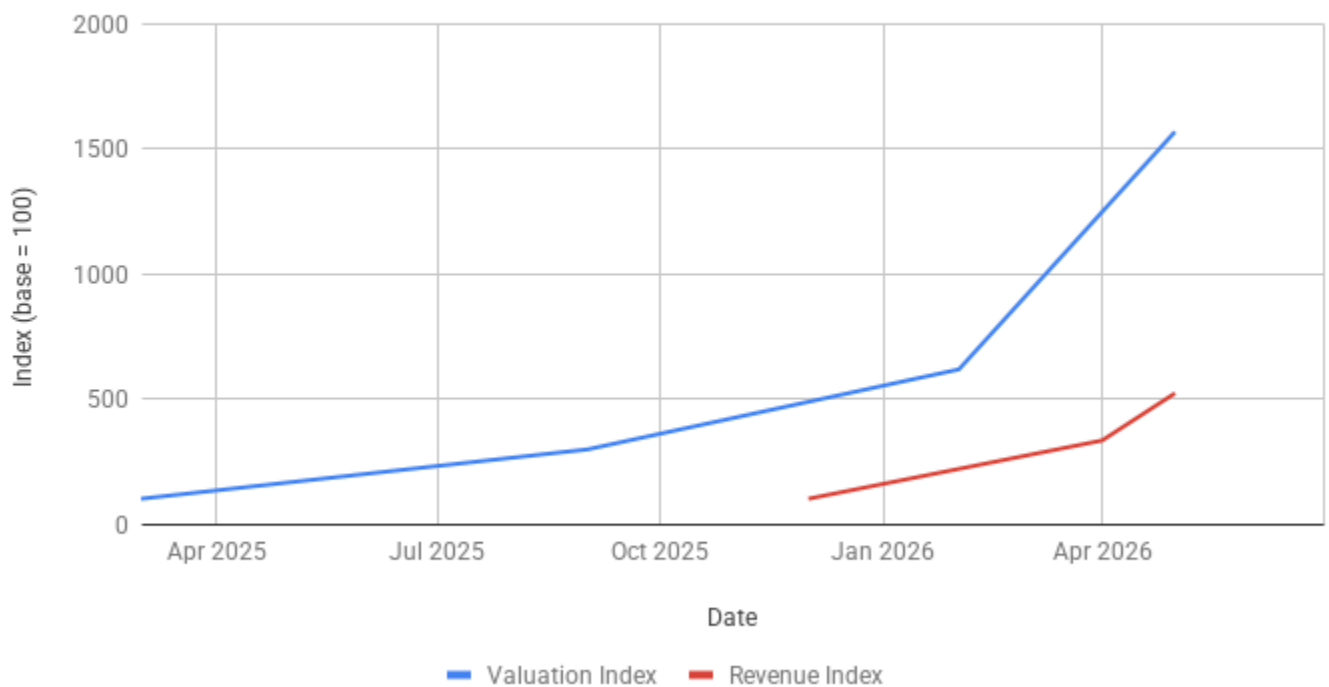
it at their jobs for real tasks, not just messing around with a chatbot. That kind of daily, practical use is a big part of why I think the revenue growth is real and not just inflated by investor excitement about AI in general.

That said, my own usage is a small, unscientific sample. What I can say is that the pattern I see personally, going from occasional curiosity to relying on the tool for actual work, mirrors what the run-rate revenue numbers suggest is happening at a much larger scale across schools, companies, and individual users.

Revenue Growth vs. Multiple Expansion

Still, real usage growing doesn't automatically mean a 16x valuation jump in about a year is fair. Revenue growth and valuation growth are not the same thing. Revenue tells you how much money is actually coming in right now. Valuation is more about what investors think the company could be worth years from now, and that number moves around a lot based on excitement, competition, and how much investment money is chasing a small number of AI companies. One analysis put it well: Anthropic's products and market hadn't really changed in that stretch, just how investors were choosing to price it (Markman, 2026). That distinction, between the business actually getting bigger and investors simply deciding to pay more for the same size business, is the part that's actually worth digging into, rather than just repeating the big headline numbers.

Valuation Growth vs. Revenue Growth (Indexed to 100)



The Cost Side Nobody Talks About

One thing that's mostly missing from the early coverage I found is Anthropic's actual costs, though a few more detailed reports fill in some of the picture. According to Reuters, Anthropic burned about \$5.6 billion in 2025, and told investors it expected to cut that to around \$3 billion in 2026, with a goal of no longer burning cash at all by 2027 (Reuters, 2026). One analysis of Anthropic's compute spending estimated the company was spending about \$4 to \$4.5 billion a year on computing power, roughly 60 percent of revenue at the time, which the report noted was meaningfully lower than the more than 75 percent of revenue that OpenAI was estimated to spend on compute (Lambda Finance, 2026). That gap matters because it suggests Anthropic isn't just growing revenue, it may actually be growing it more efficiently than its biggest competitor. Reporting from TechCrunch also indicated Anthropic was projecting its first profitable quarter in Q2 2026, which would be an unusually early milestone for an AI company at this scale (TechCrunch, 2026). That still doesn't tell me everything, since these are self-reported projections rather than audited financial statements, and a private company doesn't have to disclose the same level of detail a public company would. But it does soften my earlier concern a little: the growth doesn't look like it's purely being bought with unsustainable spending.

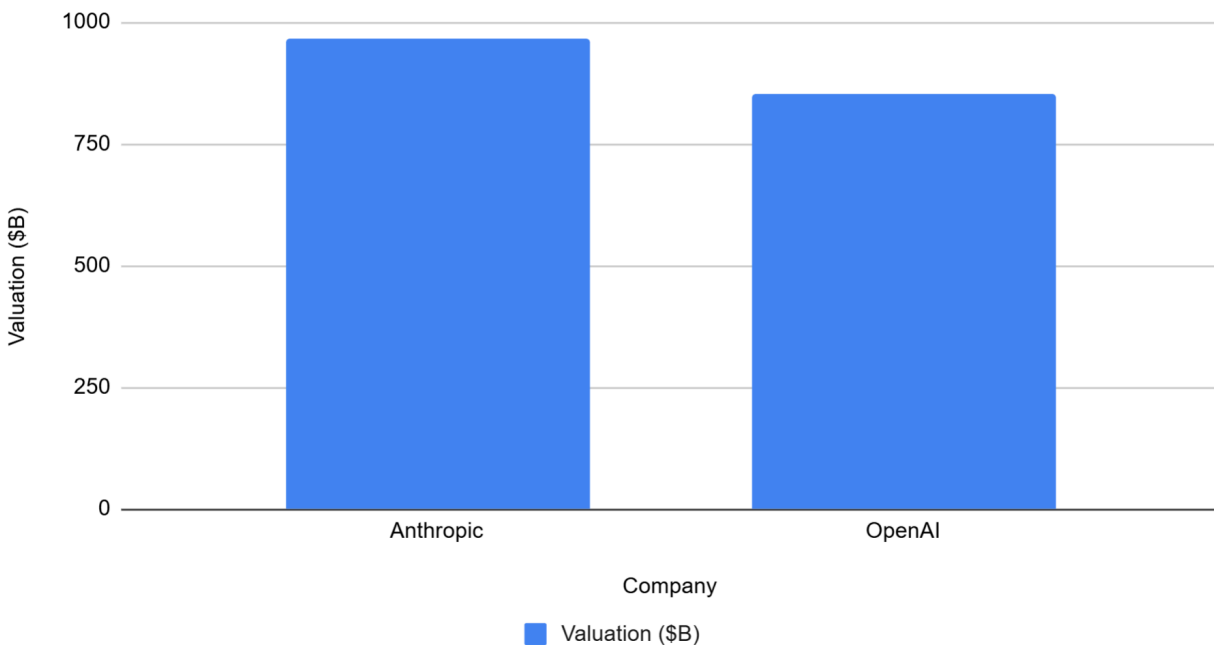
Enterprise Adoption Behind the Revenue

Part of what makes the revenue growth feel more solid to me is where it's coming from. Anthropic reported that the number of enterprise customers spending more than \$1 million a year on its products roughly doubled, from about 500 to over 1,000, in just a couple of months following its Series G round in February 2026 (MEXC, 2026). The same report noted that eight of the ten largest companies in the world by revenue were running significant workloads on Claude. That's a different kind of evidence than a single valuation headline: it suggests large organizations are integrating the product deeply enough to spend real money on it repeatedly, not just testing it once. It lines up with what I see personally too, since the shift I've noticed from people using Claude casually to relying on it for actual work seems to be happening at the enterprise level as well.

Where Anthropic Sits Against Competitors

Anthropic isn't the only company chasing this kind of valuation. Around the same time Anthropic hit \$965 billion, OpenAI was valued at about \$852 billion, meaning Anthropic had actually pulled ahead of its biggest rival in private-market pricing (Markman, 2026). That matters for how I think about the valuation, because it suggests investors aren't just pricing Anthropic in isolation, they're pricing an entire category of AI companies against each other, sometimes based on momentum as much as fundamentals. If one company's valuation jumps, it can pull the others up with it, even if the underlying businesses haven't changed by the same amount.

Anthropic vs. OpenAI Valuation (May 2026)



What Would Change My Mind

If I were actually deciding whether to invest once this goes public, here's what would move me one way or the other. On the bullish side, I'd want to see the IPO filing show healthy gross margins on the actual AI product, not just fast top-line growth, and evidence that enterprise customers are renewing and expanding their usage rather than just trying the product once. On the bearish side, I'd be cautious if the filing shows the company is still losing significant money per dollar of revenue, or if a large share of the revenue depends on a small number of very large customers who could walk away. I'd also watch how public markets react once the numbers become fully transparent, since private investors and public investors don't always agree on what a company is worth once all the financials are visible.

Conclusion

Putting the pieces together, I think the case for Anthropic is stronger than a headline valuation number makes it look, but it's not fully proven yet either. The revenue growth is backed by real adoption, both my own daily use and the jump in enterprise customers spending \$1 million or more a year, so it doesn't look like a number inflated purely by hype. The cost side is more reassuring than I expected going in: Anthropic's compute spending as a share of revenue is lower than its biggest competitor's, and the company is projecting profitability far earlier than the rest of the industry. What the evidence doesn't support, at least not yet, is the size of the valuation jump itself. A 16x increase in 14 months is larger than the revenue growth alone would justify, which means part of that number is investors pricing in a future that hasn't happened yet. The IPO filing will be the real test, since public markets will be able to check these numbers against full financial disclosures instead of investor projections. Until then, my thesis is that Anthropic looks like a genuinely strong business, but a business investors may currently be paying a premium for ahead of proof.

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